

Little Snow-white

Once upon a time in the middle of winter, when the flakes of snow were falling like feathers from the sky, a queen sat at a window sewing, and the frame of the window was made of black ebony. And whilst she was sewing and looking out of the window at the snow, she pricked her finger with the needle, and three drops of blood fell upon the snow. And the red looked pretty upon the white snow, and she thought to herself, "Would that I had a child as white as snow, as red as blood, and as black as the wood of the window-frame."

Soon after that she had a little daughter, who was as white as snow, and as red as blood, and her hair was as black as ebony; and she was therefore called Little Snow-white. And when the child was born, the Queen died.

After a year had passed the King took to himself another wife. She was a beautiful woman, but proud and haughty, and she could not bear that anyone else should surpass her in beauty. She had a wonderful looking-glass, and when she stood in front of it and looked at herself in it, and said—

"Looking-glass, Looking-glass, on the wall,

Who in this land is the fairest of all?"

the looking-glass answered—

"Thou, O Queen, art the fairest of all!"

Then she was satisfied, for she knew that the looking-glass spoke the truth.

But Snow-white was growing up, and grew more and more beautiful; and when she was seven

years old she was as beautiful as the day, and more beautiful than the Queen herself. And once when the Queen asked her looking-glass —

"Looking-glass, Looking-glass, on the wall, Who in this land is the fairest of all?"

it answered—

"Thou art fairer than all who are here, Lady Queen."

But more beautiful still is Snow-white, as I ween."

Then the Queen was shocked, and turned yellow and green with envy. From that hour, whenever

she looked at Snow-white, her heart heaved in her breast, she hated the girl so much.

And envy and pride grew higher and higher in her heart like a weed, so that she had no peace day

or night. She called a huntsman, and said, "Take the child away into the forest; I will no longer have

her in my sight. Kill her, and bring me back her heart as a token." The huntsman obeyed, and took her

away; but when he had drawn his knife, and was about to pierce Snow-white's innocent heart, she

began to weep, and said, "Ah dear huntsman, leave me my life! I will run away into the wild forest,

and never come home again."

And as she was so beautiful the huntsman had pity on her and said, "Run away, then, you poor

child." "The wild beasts will soon have devoured you," thought he, and yet it seemed as if a stone had

been rolled from his heart since it was no longer needful for him to kill her. And as a young boar just

then came running by he stabbed it, and cut out its heart and took it to the Queen as proof that the child

was dead. The cook had to salt this, and the wicked Queen ate it, and thought she had eaten the heart

of Snow-white.

But now the poor child was all alone in the great forest, and so

terrified that she looked at every

leaf of every tree, and did not know what to do. Then she began to run,

and ran over sharp stones and

through thorns, and the wild beasts ran past her, but did her no harm.

She ran as long as her feet would go until it was almost evening; then

she saw a little cottage and

went into it to rest herself. Everything in the cottage was small, but neater and cleaner than can be

told. There was a table on which was a white cover, and seven little plates, and on each plate a little

spoon; moreover, there were seven little knives and forks, and seven little mugs. Against the wall

stood seven little beds side by side, and covered with snow-white counterpanes.

Little Snow-white was so hungry and thirsty that she ate some vegetables and bread from each

plate and drank a drop of wine out of each mug, for she did not wish to take all from one only. Then,

as she was so tired, she laid herself down on one of the little beds, but none of them suited her; one

was too long, another too short, but at last she found that the seventh one was right, and so she

remained in it, said a prayer and went to sleep.

When it was quite dark the owners of the cottage came back; they were seven dwarfs who dug and

delved in the mountains for ore. They lit their seven candles, and as it was now light within the

cottage they saw that someone had been there, for everything was not in the same order in which they

had left it.

The first said, "Who has been sitting on my chair?"

The second, "Who has been eating off my plate?"

The third, "Who has been taking some of my bread?"

The fourth, "Who has been eating my vegetables?"

The fifth, "Who has been using my fork?"

The sixth, "Who has been cutting with my knife?"

The seventh, "Who has been drinking out of my mug?"

Then the first looked round and saw that there was a little hole on his bed, and he said, "Who has

been getting into my bed?" The others came up and each called out,

"Somebody has been lying in my

bed too." But the seventh when he looked at his bed saw little Snow-white, who was lying asleep therein. And he called the others, who came running up, and they cried out with astonishment, and brought their seven little candles and let the light fall on little Snow-white. "Oh, heavens! oh, heavens!" cried they, "what a lovely child!" and they were so glad that they did not wake her up, but let her sleep on in the bed. And the seventh dwarf slept with his companions, one hour with each, and so got through the night.

When it was morning little Snow-white awoke, and was frightened when she saw the seven dwarfs. But they were friendly and asked her what her name was. "My name is Snow-white," she answered. "How have you come to our house?" said the dwarfs. Then she told them that her step-mother had wished to have her killed, but that the huntsman had spared her life, and that she had run for the whole day, until at last she had found their dwelling. The dwarfs said, "If you will take care of our house, cook, make the beds, wash, sew, and knit, and if you will keep everything neat and clean, you can stay with us and you shall want for nothing." "Yes," said Snow-white, "with all my heart," and she stayed with them. She kept the house in order for them; in the mornings they went to the mountains and looked for copper and gold, in the evenings they came back, and then their supper had to be ready. The girl was alone the whole day, so the good dwarfs warned her and said, "Beware of your step-mother, she will soon know that you are here; be sure to let no one come in."

But the Queen, believing that she had eaten Snow-white's heart, could not but think that she was again the first and most beautiful of all; and she went to her looking-glass and said—

"Looking-glass, Looking-glass, on the wall,
Who in this land is the fairest of all?"

and the glass answered —

"Oh, Queen, thou art fairest of all I see,
But over the hills, where the seven dwarfs dwell,
Snow-white is still alive and well,

And none is so fair as she."

Then she was astounded, for she knew that the looking-glass never spoke falsely, and she knew that the huntsman had betrayed her, and that little Snow-white was still alive.

And so she thought and thought again how she might kill her, for so long as she was not the fairest in the whole land, envy let her have no rest. And when she had at last thought of something to do, she painted her face, and dressed herself like an old pedler-woman, and no one could have known her. In

this disguise she went over the seven mountains to the seven dwarfs, and knocked at the door and cried, "Pretty things to sell, very cheap, very cheap." Little Snow-white looked out of the window and called out, "Good-day my good woman, what have you to sell?" "Good things, pretty things," she answered; "stay-laces of all colours," and she pulled out one which was woven of bright-coloured silk. "I may let the worthy old woman in," thought Snow-white, and she unbolted the door and bought the pretty laces. "Child," said the old woman, "what a fright you look; come, I will lace you properly for once." Snow-white had no suspicion, but stood before her, and let herself be laced with the new laces. But the old woman laced so quickly and so tightly that Snow-white lost her breath and fell down as if dead. "Now I am the most beautiful," said the Queen to herself, and ran away. Not long afterwards, in the evening, the seven dwarfs came home, but how shocked they were when they saw their dear little Snow-white lying on the ground, and that she neither stirred nor moved, and seemed to be dead. They lifted her up, and, as they saw that she was laced too tightly, they cut the laces; then she began to breathe a little, and after a while came to life again. When the dwarfs heard what had happened they said, "The old pedler-woman was no one else than the wicked Queen; take care and let no one come in when we are not with you." But the wicked woman when she had reached home went in front of the glass and asked—

"Looking-glass, Looking-glass, on the wall,
Who in this land is the fairest of all?"

and it answered as before—

"Oh, Queen, thou art fairest of all I see,
But over the hills, where the seven dwarfs dwell,
Snow-white is still alive and well,

And none is so fair as she."

When she heard that, all her blood rushed to her heart with fear, for she saw plainly that little

Snow-white was again alive. "But now," she said, "I will think of something that shall put an end to

you," and by the help of witchcraft, which she understood, she made a poisonous comb. Then she

disguised herself and took the shape of another old woman. So she went over the seven mountains to

the seven dwarfs, knocked at the door, and cried, "Good things to sell, cheap, cheap!" Little Snow-

white looked out and said, "Go away; I cannot let any one come in." "I suppose you can look," said

the old woman, and pulled the poisonous comb out and held it up. It pleased the girl so well that she

let herself be beguiled, and opened the door. When they had made a bargain the old woman said,

"Now I will comb you properly for once." Poor little Snow-white had no suspicion, and let the old woman do as she pleased, but hardly had she put the comb in her hair than the poison in it took effect, and the girl fell down senseless. "You paragon of beauty," said the wicked woman, "you are done for now," and she went away.

But fortunately it was almost evening, when the seven dwarfs came home. When they saw Snow-white lying as if dead upon the ground they at once suspected the step-mother, and they looked and found the poisoned comb. Scarcely had they taken it out when Snow-white came to herself, and told them what had happened. Then they warned her once more to be upon her guard and to open the door to no one.

The Queen, at home, went in front of the glass and said—

"Looking-glass, Looking-glass, on the wall,
Who in this land is the fairest of all?"

then it answered as before—

"Oh, Queen, thou art fairest of all I see,
But over the hills, where the seven dwarfs dwell,
Snow-white is still alive and well,

And none is so fair as she."

When she heard the glass speak thus she trembled and shook with rage.

"Snow-white shall die," she cried, "even if it costs me my life!"

Thereupon she went into a quite secret, lonely room, where no one ever came, and there she made

a very poisonous apple. Outside it looked pretty, white with a red cheek, so that everyone who saw it

longed for it; but whoever ate a piece of it must surely die.

When the apple was ready she painted her face, and dressed herself up as a country-woman, and

so she went over the seven mountains to the seven dwarfs. She knocked at the door. Snow-white put

her head out of the window and said, "I cannot let any one in; the seven dwarfs have forbidden me."

"It is all the same to me," answered the woman, "I shall soon get rid of my apples. There, I will give you one."

"No," said Snow-white, "I dare not take anything." "Are you afraid of poison?" said the old

woman; "look, I will cut the apple in two pieces; you eat the red cheek, and I will eat the white." The

apple was so cunningly made that only the red cheek was poisoned. Snow-white longed for the fine

apple, and when she saw that the woman ate part of it she could resist no longer, and stretched out her

hand and took the poisonous half. But hardly had she a bit of it in her mouth than she fell down dead.

Then the Queen looked at her with a dreadful look, and laughed aloud and said, "White as snow, red

as blood, black as ebony-wood! this time the dwarfs cannot wake you up again."

And when she asked of the Looking-glass at home—

"Looking-glass, Looking-glass, on the wall,
Who in this land is the fairest of all?"

it answered at last —

"Oh, Queen, in this land thou art fairest of all."

Then her envious heart had rest, so far as an envious heart can have rest.

The dwarfs, when they came home in the evening, found Snow-white lying upon the ground; she

breathed no longer and was dead. They lifted her up, looked to see whether they could find anything

poisonous, unlaced her, combed her hair, washed her with water and wine, but it was all of no use;

the poor child was dead, and remained dead. They laid her upon a bier, and all seven of them sat

round it and wept for her, and wept three days long.

Then they were going to bury her, but she still looked as if she were living, and still had her pretty

red cheeks. They said, "We could not bury her in the dark ground," and they had a transparent coffin of

glass made, so that she could be seen from all sides, and they laid her in it, and wrote her name upon

it in golden letters, and that she was a king's daughter. Then they put the coffin out upon the mountain,

and one of them always stayed by it and watched it. And birds came too, and wept for Snow-white;

first an owl, then a raven, and last a dove.

And now Snow-white lay a long, long time in the coffin, and she did not change, but looked as if

she were asleep; for she was as white as snow, as red as blood, and her hair was as black as ebony.

It happened, however, that a king's son came into the forest, and went to the dwarfs' house to

spend the night. He saw the coffin on the mountain, and the beautiful Snow-white within it, and read

what was written upon it in golden letters. Then he said to the dwarfs, "Let me have the coffin, I will

give you whatever you want for it." But the dwarfs answered, "We will not part with it for all the gold

in the world." Then he said, "Let me have it as a gift, for I cannot live without seeing Snow-white. I

will honour and prize her as my dearest possession." As he spoke in this way the good dwarfs took

pity upon him, and gave him the coffin.

And now the King's son had it carried away by his servants on their shoulders. And it happened

that they stumbled over a tree-stump, and with the shock the poisonous piece of apple which Snow-

white had bitten off came out of her throat. And before long she opened her eyes, lifted up the lid of

the coffin, sat up, and was once more alive. "Oh, heavens, where am I?" she cried. The King's son,

full of joy, said, "You are with me," and told her what had happened, and said, "I love you more than

everything in the world; come with me to my father's palace, you shall be my wife."

And Snow-white was willing, and went with him, and their wedding was held with great show

and splendour. But Snow-white's wicked step-mother was also bidden to the feast. When she had

arrayed herself in beautiful clothes she went before the Looking-glass, and said—

"Looking-glass, Looking-glass, on the wall,

Who in this land is the fairest of all?"

the glass answered—

"Oh, Queen, of all here the fairest art thou,

But the young Queen is fairer by far as I trow."

Then the wicked woman uttered a curse, and was so wretched, so utterly wretched, that she knew

not what to do. At first she would not go to the wedding at all, but she had no peace, and must go to

see the young Queen. And when she went in she knew Snow-white; and she stood still with rage and

fear, and could not stir. But iron slippers had already been put upon the fire, and they were brought in

with tongs, and set before her. Then she was forced to put on the red-hot shoes, and dance until she dropped down dead.

Little Red-Cap

Once upon a time there was a dear little girl who was loved by every one who looked at her, but

most of all by her grandmother, and there was nothing that she would not have given to the child. Once

she gave her a little cap of red velvet, which suited her so well that she would never wear anything

else; so she was always called "Little Red-Cap."

One day her mother said to her, "Come, Little Red-Cap, here is a piece of cake and a bottle of

wine; take them to your grandmother, she is ill and weak, and they will do her good. Set out before it

gets hot, and when you are going, walk nicely and quietly and do not run off the path, or you may fall

and break the bottle, and then your grandmother will get nothing; and when you go into her room, don't

forget to say, 'Good-morning,' and don't peep into every corner before you do it."

"I will take great care," said Little Red-Cap to her mother, and gave her hand on it.

The grandmother lived out in the wood, half a league from the village, and just as Little Red-Cap

entered the wood, a wolf met her. Red-Cap did not know what a wicked creature he was, and was not

at all afraid of him.

"Good-day, Little Red-Cap," said he.

"Thank you kindly, wolf."

"Whither away so early, Little Red-Cap?"

"To my grandmother's."

"What have you got in your apron?"

"Cake and wine; yesterday was baking-day, so poor sick grandmother is to have something good, to make her stronger."

"Where does your grandmother live, Little Red-Cap?"

"A good quarter of a league farther on in the wood; her house stands under the three large oak-trees, the nut-trees are just below; you surely must know it," replied Little Red-Cap.

The wolf thought to himself, "What a tender young creature! what a nice plump mouthful—she

will be better to eat than the old woman. I must act craftily, so as to catch both." So he walked for a

short time by the side of Little Red-Cap, and then he said, "See Little Red-Cap, how pretty the

flowers are about here—why do you not look round? I believe, too, that you do not hear how sweetly

the little birds are singing; you walk gravely along as if you were going to school, while everything

else out here in the wood is merry."

Little Red-Cap raised her eyes, and when she saw the sunbeams dancing here and there through

the trees, and pretty flowers growing everywhere, she thought, "Suppose I take grandmother a fresh

nosegay; that would please her too. It is so early in the day that I shall still get there in good time;"

and so she ran from the path into the wood to look for flowers. And whenever she had picked one, she

fancied that she saw a still prettier one farther on, and ran after it, and so got deeper and deeper into

the wood.

Meanwhile the wolf ran straight to the grandmother's house and knocked at the door.

"Who is there?"

"Little Red-Cap," replied the wolf. "She is bringing cake and wine; open the door."

"Lift the latch," called out the grandmother, "I am too weak, and cannot get up."

The wolf lifted the latch, the door flew open, and without saying a word he went straight to the

grandmother's bed, and devoured her. Then he put on her clothes, dressed himself in her cap, laid

himself in bed and drew the curtains.

Little Red-Cap, however, had been running about picking flowers, and when she had gathered so

many that she could carry no more, she remembered her grandmother, and set out on the way to her.

She was surprised to find the cottage-door standing open, and when she went into the room, she

had such a strange feeling that she said to herself, "Oh dear! how uneasy I feel to-day, and at other

times I like being with grandmother so much." She called out, "Good morning," but received no answer; so she went to the bed and drew back the curtains. There lay her grandmother with her cap pulled far over her face, and looking very strange.

"Oh! grandmother," she said, "what big ears you have!"

"The better to hear you with, my child," was the reply.

"But, grandmother, what big eyes you have!" she said.

"The better to see you with, my dear."

"But, grandmother, what large hands you have!"

"The better to hug you with."

"Oh! but, grandmother, what a terrible big mouth you have!"

"The better to eat you with!"

And scarcely had the wolf said this, than with one bound he was out of bed and swallowed up

Red-Cap.

When the wolf had appeased his appetite, he lay down again in the bed, fell asleep and began to

snore very loud. The huntsman was just passing the house, and thought to himself, "How the old

woman is snoring! I must just see if she wants anything." So he went into the room, and when he came

to the bed, he saw that the wolf was lying in it. "Do I find thee here, thou old sinner!" said he. "I have

long sought thee!" Then just as he was going to fire at him, it occurred to him that the wolf might have

devoured the grandmother, and that she might still be saved, so he did not fire, but took a pair of

scissors, and began to cut open the stomach of the sleeping wolf. When he had made two snips, he

saw the little Red-Cap shining, and then he made two snips more, and the little girl sprang out, crying,

"Ah, how frightened I have been! How dark it was inside the wolf;" and after that the aged

grandmother came out alive also, but scarcely able to breathe. Red-Cap, however, quickly fetched

great stones with which they filled the wolf's body, and when he awoke, he wanted to run away, but

the stones were so heavy that he fell down at once, and fell dead.

Then all three were delighted. The huntsman drew off the wolf's skin and went home with it; the

grandmother ate the cake and drank the wine which Red-Cap had brought, and revived, but Red-Cap

thought to herself, "As long as I live, I will never by myself leave the path, to run into the wood, when

my mother has forbidden me to do so."

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It is also related that once when Red-Cap was again taking cakes to the old grandmother, another

wolf spoke to her, and tried to entice her from the path. Red-Cap, however, was on her guard, and

went straight forward on her way, and told her grandmother that she had met the wolf, and that he had said "good-morning" to her, but with such a wicked look in his eyes, that if they had not been on the public road she was certain he would have eaten her up. "Well," said the grandmother, "we will shut the door, that he may not come in." Soon afterwards the wolf knocked, and cried, "Open the door, grandmother, I am little Red-Cap, and am fetching you some cakes." But they did not speak, or open the door, so the grey-beard stole twice or thrice round the house, and at last jumped on the roof, intending to wait until Red-Cap went home in the evening, and then to steal after her and devour her in the darkness. But the grandmother saw what was in his thoughts. In front of the house was a great stone trough, so she said to the child, "Take the pail, Red-Cap; I made some sausages yesterday, so carry the water in which I boiled them to the trough." Red-Cap carried until the great trough was quite full. Then the smell of the sausages reached the wolf, and he sniffed and peeped down, and at last stretched out his neck so far that he could no longer keep his footing and began to slip, and slipped down from the roof straight into the great trough, and was drowned. But Red-Cap went joyously home, and never did anything to harm any one.

Rumpelstiltskin

Once there was a miller who was poor, but who had a beautiful daughter. Now it happened that he had to go and speak to the King, and in order to make himself appear important he said to him, "I have a daughter who can spin straw into gold." The King said to the miller, "That is an art which pleases me well; if your daughter is as clever as you say, bring her to-morrow to my palace, and I will try what she can do." And when the girl was brought to him he took her into a room which was quite full of straw, gave her a spinning-wheel and a reel, and said, "Now set to work, and if by to-morrow morning early you have not spun this straw into gold during the night, you must die." Thereupon he himself locked up the room, and left her in it alone. So there sat the poor miller's daughter, and for the life of her could not tell what to do; she had no idea how straw could be spun into gold, and she grew more and more miserable, until at last she began to weep. But all at once the door opened, and in came a little man, and said, "Good evening, Mistress

Miller; why are you crying so?" "Alas!" answered the girl, "I have to spin straw into gold, and I do not know how to do it." "What will you give me," said the manikin, "if I do it for you?" "My necklace," said the girl. The little man took the necklace, seated himself in front of the wheel, and "whirr, whirr, whirr," three turns, and the reel was full; then he put another on, and whirr, whirr, whirr, three times round, and the second was full too. And so it went on until the morning, when all the straw was spun, and all the reels were full of gold. By daybreak the King was already there, and when he saw the gold he was astonished and delighted, but his heart became only more greedy. He had the miller's daughter taken into another room full of straw, which was much larger, and commanded her to spin that also in one night if she valued her life. The girl knew not how to help herself, and was crying, when the door again opened, and the little man appeared, and said, "What will you give me if I spin that straw into gold for you?" "The ring on my finger," answered the girl. The little man took the ring, again began to turn the wheel, and by morning had spun all the straw into glittering gold. The King rejoiced beyond measure at the sight, but still he had not gold enough; and he had the miller's daughter taken into a still larger room full of straw, and said, "You must spin this, too, in the course of this night; but if you succeed, you shall be my wife." "Even if she be a miller's daughter," thought he, "I could not find a richer wife in the whole world." When the girl was alone the manikin came again for the third time, and said, "What will you give me if I spin the straw for you this time also?" "I have nothing left that I could give," answered the girl. "Then promise me, if you should become Queen, your first child." "Who knows whether that will ever happen?" thought the miller's daughter; and, not knowing how else to help herself in this strait, she promised the manikin what he wanted, and for that he once more spun the straw into gold. And when the King came in the morning, and found all as he had wished, he took her in marriage, and the pretty miller's daughter became a Queen. A year after, she had a beautiful child, and she never gave a thought to the manikin. But suddenly he came into her room, and said, "Now give me what you promised." The Queen was horror-struck, and offered the manikin all the riches of the kingdom if he would leave her the child. But the manikin said, "No, something that is living is dearer to me than all the treasures in the world." Then the Queen

began to weep and cry, so that the manikin pitied her. "I will give you three days' time," said he, "if by that time you find out my name, then shall you keep your child." So the Queen thought the whole night of all the names that she had ever heard, and she sent a messenger over the country to inquire, far and wide, for any other names that there might be. When the manikin came the next day, she began with Caspar, Melchior, Balthazar, and said all the names she knew, one after another; but to every one the little man said, "That is not my name." On the second day she had inquiries made in the neighborhood as to the names of the people there, and she repeated to the manikin the most uncommon and curious. "Perhaps your name is Shortribs, or Sheepshanks, or Laceleg?" but he always answered, "That is not my name." On the third day the messenger came back again, and said, "I have not been able to find a single new name, but as I came to a high mountain at the end of the forest, where the fox and the hare bid each other good night, there I saw a little house, and before the house a fire was burning, and round about the fire quite a ridiculous little man was jumping: he hopped upon one leg, and shouted—

"To-day I bake, to-morrow brew,
The next I'll have the young Queen's child.
Ha! glad am I that no one knew
That Rumpelstiltskin I am styled."

You may think how glad the Queen was when she heard the name! And when soon afterwards the little man came in, and asked, "Now, Mistress Queen, what is my name?" at first she said, "Is your name Conrad?" "No." "Is your name Harry?" "No." "Perhaps your name is Rumpelstiltskin?" "The devil has told you that! the devil has told you that!" cried the little man, and in his anger he plunged his right foot so deep into the earth that his whole leg went in; and then in rage he pulled at his left leg so hard with both hands that he tore himself in two